social distancing is followed. Numbers would also significantly increase if people were cramped in an indoor, non-ventilated, humid space.

The Nizamuddin Markaz mosque is a standalone, six-storey building with a capacity to house over 2,000 people, sharing a wall with the local Hazrat Nizamuddin Police Station in West Delhi. On 12 March, following the transmission scare at a children's birthday party and persistently growing daily new cases, the New Delhi government, invoking powers granted by the Epidemic Diseases Act of 1897, announced the shutdown of schools, cinema halls and colleges. Private offices too had begun to operate via remote working.[4] On 13 March, over 3,400 people were reported to be inside the mosque. On 16 March, the Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal announced that no more than 50 people would be allowed at religious, political or social gatherings. While some attendees at the Markaz began to leave and make their way to several parts of the country, others continued to stay put, defying government orders.[5]



Meanwhile, Prof. VijayRaghavan and Dr Paul had a meeting scheduled with the principal secretary and other officials at the PMO to discuss their grim findings after extensive consultations with modellers. Numerous heads of states and their deputies have walked the same wide red-stone hallways through which the two gentlemen made their way to Dr Mishra's first-floor chamber, adjacent to the prime minister's. In the pyramid of India's government, the person empowered to advise and expected to urge caution to a prime minister is the principal secretary. As the bureaucrat-in-chief, he is not only the prime minister's eyes and ears, but is also the official responsible for knowing whether the government machinery is functioning as directed. In this time of crisis, Dr Mishra's job was cut out; one of his main tasks was to understand the developing crisis and assess the advice the prime minister was receiving, especially from scientists.

Although new techniques of modelling have not reached a point where they can make accurate predictions on the rise of an unknown agent beyond two to four weeks[6], a relatively safe bet was to use various different kinds of models using data points from around the world where the contagion was significantly spreading and input them in an instrument which was tailored for Indian demographics and patterns. The challenge was to find, produce